How to Get Strong

A Barbell Training Program for Beginners

📊 Level: Beginner | ⏱️ 4 Weeks | 💪 3 Days/Week

🎯 Program Overview

This is a program that is guaranteed to get you stronger, while helping you master the most important strength training exercises:

- **Squat**
- **Deadlift**
- **Bench Press**
- **Overhead Press**
- **Barbell Row**

Why These Movements?

They train the most muscle mass in the shortest time. Master these five and you'll have a strength foundation that transfers to everything else.

What Makes This Different?

- **Simple progression** — Add weight every session
- **Just 3 days per week** — Recovery built in
- **No fluff** — No curls, ab work, or fancy accessories until you earn them

> **Program Note:** This is based on the Starting Strength program by Mark Rippetoe, with one change: I swap deadlifts for bent over rows on Day A. From training clients in the real world, I've found this to be the most effective way for beginners to build strength.

👤 Who Is This For?

This program is for you if:

- You're new to strength training (0-6 months experience)
- You have access to a barbell and power rack
- You can train 3 days per week consistently
- You want to get stronger, build muscle, and learn proper form

Equipment Needed

- Barbell
- Power rack or squat stands
- Bench (flat or adjustable)
- Plates (25s, 10s, 5s, 2.5s)

📅 The Training Schedule

3 days per week:

- **Day A:** Squat, Bench, Row
- **Day B:** Squat, Overhead Press, Deadlift

Sample Week 1:

- Monday: Day A
- Wednesday: Day B
- Friday: Day A

Sample Week 2:

- Monday: Day B
- Wednesday: Day A
- Friday: Day B

Alternate A/B every session. That's it.

💪 Week 1-4 Workouts

Day A: Squat, Bench, Row

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Rest
Back Squat	3 x 5	3 min
Bench Press	3 x 5	3 min
Barbell Row	3 x 5	3 min

Day B: Squat, Overhead Press, Deadlift

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Rest
Back Squat	3 x 5	3 min
Overhead Press	3 x 5	3 min
Deadlift	1 x 5	3 min

Why only 1 set of deadlifts? Deadlifts are brutal. One heavy set is enough for beginners. You're also squatting 3x per week, which hits similar muscles.

📈 Progression Rules

Week 1: Find Your Starting Weights

Your first week is about finding weights you can lift with clean form for 3 sets of 5 reps, leaving 1-2 reps in the tank.

> **Rule:** • If your last rep looks slow but clean → that's perfect • If your form breaks down → it's too heavy • If it feels easy → it's too light

Weeks 2-4: Linear Progression

Add weight every session:

- **Lower body (squat, deadlift):** +10 lbs per session
- **Upper body (bench, press, row):** +5 lbs per session

Critical Rule: Perfect reps > adding weight.

What If I Fail a Set?

If you can't complete all 3 sets of 5 reps:

1. **First time:** Repeat the same weight next session
2. **Second time in a row:** Drop 10% and rebuild

> **Example:** Session 5: 185 lbs squat — only got 5, 5, 4 reps (failed last set) • Session 6: Repeat 185 lbs — got 5, 5, 5 (success) • Session 7: Add 5 lbs (instead of 10) → 190 lbs

Don't rush the progression. **Slow and steady wins.**

🔥 Warm-Up Protocol

General Warm-Up (5 minutes):

- Light cardio (bike, row, jog) to break a sweat
- Dynamic stretches (leg swings, arm circles, cat-cow)

Lift-Specific Warm-Up:

For Squat/Deadlift:

- Bar x 10 reps
- 95 lbs x 5 reps
- 135 lbs x 3 reps
- Add weight until you hit your working weight

For Bench/Press/Row:

- Bar x 10 reps
- 65 lbs x 5 reps
- Add weight until you hit your working weight

> **Rule of thumb:** Do 2-4 warm-up sets, increasing weight each time. Never go to failure on warm-ups.

🚀 After Week 4: What's Next?

If you completed all 4 weeks and made progress:

Continue with the same program for another 4-8 weeks. Linear progression works until it doesn't.

If you're stalling:

- Check your sleep (are you getting 7-9 hours?)
- Check your nutrition (are you eating enough?)
- Check your form (film your lifts, compare to the Form Guide)

If you're crushing it and want more volume:

Email me at ian@cypresstrainingcenter.com. I'll send you the next program (Intermediate 4-Day Split).

❓ FAQs

1. Can I add more exercises?

Not yet. Master the Big 5 first. After 8-12 weeks, we can add accessories (curls, tricep work, ab training).

2. What about cardio?

2-3 sessions per week, 20-30 minutes, easy pace (Zone 2). Don't run a 10K the day before squats.

3. How much should I eat?

To build muscle: Eat in a slight surplus (200-300 calories above maintenance) • **To lose fat:** Eat in a slight deficit (200-300 calories below maintenance) • **To maintain:** Eat at maintenance

Prioritize protein: 0.8-1g per lb of bodyweight.

4. Do I need supplements?

No. Eat enough protein, sleep 7-9 hours, stay hydrated. Supplements are 5% of the equation. If you want to supplement: **Creatine** (5g/day), **Protein powder**, **Caffeine** pre-workout.

5. What if I miss a workout?

Life happens. Just pick up where you left off. Don't try to "make up" missed workouts by doubling up.

6. Can I train 4 or 5 days per week?

You can, but you don't need to. More isn't always better. Stick with 3 days for the first 12 weeks. Add volume when progress stalls.

7. My lower back is sore after squats/deadlifts. Is that normal?

Some soreness is normal. Sharp pain or pain that doesn't go away is not. Check your form. Film yourself. Email me if you're unsure.

Let's Get to Work

This program is simple. It's not fancy. It doesn't have drop sets, supersets, or Instagram-friendly circuits.

But it works.

Show up 3x per week. Add weight when you can. Eat and sleep enough.

Do that for 12 weeks and you'll be stronger than 90% of people in your gym.

Questions? Email me at **ian@cypresstrainingcenter.com**

Get Started